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Roof, housetop

3.1.5 Roof, housetop

References:

Hebrew גָּג (gag) DEU 22:8, JOS 2:6, JOS 2:6, JOS 2:8, JDG 9:51, JDG 16:27, 1SA 9:25, 1SA 9:26, 2SA 11:2, 2SA 11:2, 2SA 16:22, 2SA 18:24, 2KI 19:26, 2KI 23:12, NEH 8:16, PSA 102:8, PSA 129:6, PRO 21:9, PRO 25:24, ISA 15:3, ISA 22:1, ISA 37:27, JER 19:13, JER 32:29, JER 48:38, EZK 40:13, EZK 40:13, ZEP 1:5

Hebrew מְקֶרֶה (mqareh) ECC 10:18

Hebrew קוֹרָה (qorah) GEN 19:8

Greek δῶμα (dōma) MAT 10:27, MAT 24:17, MRK 13:15, LUK 5:19, LUK 12:3, LUK 17:31, ACT 10:9, JDT 8:5

Greek ὄροφος (orofos) WIS 17:2

Greek στέγη (stegē) MAT 8:8, MRK 2:4, LUK 7:6, 4MA 17:3, 1ES 6:4

Description:

Houses in biblical times had flat roofs. These were often surrounded by a low wall or parapet (see 3.1.5.1 Parapet, retaining wall<REALIA:3.1.5.1>) that prevented people or objects from falling off. They were made of a base of heavy wooden beams. These were overlaid with branches or grass, which was then covered with dirt, sometimes mixed with lime or stone. The dirt was pounded flat or rolled down with a heavy stone roller. The roof was normally reached by outside stairs along a wall of the house. See the illustrations at 3.1 House, permanent dwelling<REALIA:3.1> and 3.1.5.3 Crossbeam, rafter<REALIA:3.1.5.3>.

Usage:

The roof of the house served several purposes. Certain produce was dried there in the sun. In the evening people sometimes sat on the roof in order to enjoy the cool breeze at the end of a hot day. The roof could also serve as a storage area. It was much more commonly the focus of activity than is true in many cultures today.

Translation:

In view of the various types of activities described as taking place on the housetop, it may be important in some languages to indicate, either in the text or in a marginal note, the fact that such housetops were flat and that there was usually easy access to the roof. This will be especially true for JOS 2:6; JOS 2:8; JDG 16:27; 2SA 11:2; 2SA 16:22; JER 19:13; JER 32:29; MAT 24:17; MRK 13:15; LUK 17:31; ACT 10:9.

Where the normal term for "roof" suggests a pitched roof, the expression will have to be adjusted with a descriptive phrase, such as "top of the house" or "flat house top."

GEN 19:8: At the end of this verse the literal expression "they have come under the shadow of my roof beam" will probably not be understood. As Lot's guests, the men are under his protection. Even the rendering "they have come under the shelter [or, protection] of my roof" (so RSV) may not be clear or convey the full significance in some languages. The short Hebrew phrase here is expanded by GNT to "they are guests in my house, and I must protect them."

Several Old Testament verses speak of grass growing on the housetop. To make this understandable, it may be necessary to explain in a footnote how roofs were constructed. Three Old Testament passages compare human beings to "grass on the housetops" (2KI 19:26; PSA 129:6; ISA 37:27). The basis of comparison is the fleeting, transitory character of the life of the people involved. In many cultures, however, grass is used as a roofing material, and it is precisely the grass that has lived long and grown strong that is selected for such thatch. In those languages where a literal rendering would present difficulties to certain readers, the translator should try to find a more natural figure of speech without the word "housetop" in it; for example, "grass in the gutters" or "grass growing in the walls."

MAT 10:27; LUK 12:3: The phrase "proclaim from the housetops" (NJB in MAT 10:27) is an idiom meaning "proclaim publicly." Compare the following model in *A Handbook on The Gospel of Matthew*: "you must announce to all the world" (page 306).

For more discussion on how to translate the words "roof" and "housetop," see John Ellington's article "Up on the Housetop."

Parapet, retaining wall

3.1.5.1 Parapet, retaining wall

Reference:

Hebrew מַעֲקֶה (maʿaqeh) DEU 22:8

Description and usage:

The parapet was a low stone wall built around the flat roof of a house to prevent people or things from falling off. See the illustration at 3.1 House, permanent dwelling<REALIA:3.1>.

Translation:

Most translations use a single word to render the Hebrew word *maʿaqeh*, for example, "parapet" (RSV) and "railing" (GNT). NCV and CEV have "low wall," while SPCL "protective wall" is also good. The context of DEU 22:8 makes the purpose of the parapet clear as seen in the GNT rendering of this verse: "When you build a new house, be sure to put a railing around the edge of the roof. Then you will not be responsible if someone falls off and is killed." Where possible and necessary, it is advisable to add a note explaining the nature and uses of the roof of an Israelite house (see 3.1.5 Roof, housetop<REALIA:3.1.5>).

Roof tile

3.1.5.2 Roof tile

Reference:

Greek κέραμος (keramos) LUK 5:19

Description and usage:

Clay roof tiles (© Arivumathi, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The roof tile was a thin slab or bent piece of baked clay used to cover a pitched roof. It is also possible that LUK 5:19 is speaking of thin, flat stones.

Translation:

Clay tiles on roof (© Ray Pritz by United Bible Societies)While the normal Israelite house did not have roof tiles, LUK 5:19 mentions them specifically. Roof tiles were part of Greek roof construction, although by the time of the New Testament they were also known in the land of Israel. Many suggestions have been made to understand this seeming anomaly, but the translator should translate the text as it is.

"Roof tiles" has been rendered "flat stones" or, more generically, "covering" or "roofing." Where a roofing material other than tiles is known, it may be necessary to adjust the literal clause "through the tiles they let him down on his bed," for example, "they parted the roof [of split bamboo] and lowered him on his bed" or, without reference to the material, "where the housetop was opened by them, they lowered him on his bed." NCV eliminates any mention of making a hole: "they … lowered the man on his mat through the ceiling."

Crossbeam, rafter

3.1.5.3 Crossbeam, rafter

References:

Aramaic אָע (ʾaʿ) EZR 6:11

Hebrew גֵּב (gev) 1KI 6:9

Hebrew כָּפִיס (kafis) HAB 2:11

Hebrew קרה, קוֹרָה (qarah (verb), qorah) 2CH 3:7, SNG 1:17, 2CH 34:11

Hebrew רָהִיט (rachit) SNG 1:17

Hebrew שְׂדֵרָה (sderah) 1KI 6:9

Greek δοκός (dokos) SIR 29:22, LJE 1:19, LJE 1:54

Greek ἱμάντωσις (himantōsis) SIR 22:16

Greek ξύλον (xulon) 1ES 6:31

Description and usage:

Roof beams in a house (© Hagit Baldar, CC BY, via Wikimedia Commons)The roof of an Israelite house was made of three or even four layers. First thick wooden poles were laid between two walls at the top and along the length of the house. These were inserted in the top of the wall and were part of the wall structure. If they were removed, the wall would be heavily damaged. These "crossbeams" or "rafters" were separated from each other at a distance about the length of a man's forearm. On top of these crossbeams and perpendicular to them was laid a layer of smaller poles, roughly 3–4 centimeters (1–2 inches) in diameter. These poles were laid side by side to create a platform. They are probably mentioned in 1KI 6:9 as *sderoth* (plural of *sderah*). On top of the smaller poles there was a layer of dirt and sometimes on top of the dirt a layer of tiles.

Translation:

While the meaning of the Hebrew word *gev* is uncertain in 1KI 6:9, all the translations consulted render it "beams." See also the discussion on this word at 3.1.6 Room<REALIA:3.1.6>.

In SNG 1:17 the Hebrew word *rachit* is used figuratively, and there is also a textual problem. See the discussion of this verse in *A Handbook on Song of Songs*, page 49.

HAB 2:11: The Hebrew word *kafis* appears only here in Scripture, but most translations agree that it refers to a rafter or crossbeam in a house. NRSV differs by rendering the last line of this verse as "and the plaster will respond from the woodwork." Babylonian houses were usually built with brick rather than stone, and the prophet is describing Babylonian homes in terms of the building materials he was familiar with in the land of Israel. In a similar way some translators may have to speak of building materials in common use in their own areas (such as clay and wood, or wood and thatch), rather than try to describe "crossbeams" or "rafters"; for example, they may say "and the wood [or, thatch/clay] in the roof cries back [or, echoes the

cry].” In some languages it may not be possible to speak of building materials crying out like people. In such cases it may be possible to use a simile and render the whole verse as “It will be as if even the stones and woodwork of your houses bore witness against your evil deeds.”

The crossbeam provided essential support for the building. In EZR 6:11 and 1ES 6:31 the act of removing a beam from a person’s house will certainly cause it to fall. So an alternative rendering for the middle of these verses is “his house will be destroyed, and one of its wooden beams will be driven through his body.”